

Grown-up's Playbook: The Swan Children's Lullaby

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Swan Children's Lullaby: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale: nobody is ever frightened for long, no one is hurt, and cleverness and kindness win every time.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Roundhouse.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (quick, clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: anything at all for the little harp, a leaf or twig for the sprig of oak, and a small cake or token for the honey oatcake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. By the misty loch, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts off the loch, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only four shy swan children who have lost their song. The story is won not by beating anyone but by drawing near gently, helping the swan children remember their lullaby, and then playing the little harp so they find their voices again. The shyest swan finding her note is the heart of it; let that moment land. When the song returns, the mist lifts into rose and gold, the Ring of Standing Stones hums, and Danu the Kind smiles. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Swan Children's Lullaby: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Grey Mist (Easy)

The challenge. A thick grey mist hides the four swan children on the loch. The players need to find them and draw near without frightening them away.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Observation moment. The clever, kind move is to slow right down: stand still and listen for a ripple or a soft feathered sound, then call out gently and warmly so the swans know a friend has come. Loud or sudden approaches make the swans shrink back into the mist; a calm, kind one brings them gliding out.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a single white feather drift to their feet, or let the smallest swan give a quiet call they can follow. Any gentle, kind approach works, and once the swans see a friendly face they come close on their own.

Stop 2: Remembering the Lullaby (Normal)

The challenge. The swan children have forgotten their lullaby. Three short verses are drifting in the mist all out of order, and the song will not work until the players put them back the right way.

The verses. Read them aloud in a jumbled order, then ask the children to sort them. Number them only for yourself.

1. *Soft falls the dusk on the silver loch, little ones, rest your weary wings.* 2. *Up lifts the mist, all rose and gold, and the ring of old grey stones still sings.* 3. *Sleep now, sleep, till the morning sun wakes the world with the song it brings.*

The ordering clue. Tell the children the lullaby travels through one whole night: it starts at dusk, rises through the dark, and ends at the morning sun. The words that name the time of day give the order away: **dusk** comes first, then the **mist lifting** in rose and gold, then **the morning sun** last. So the right order is verse 1, then verse 2, then verse 3.

Intended solution. This is a Memory and Vocabulary moment. The players listen for the time-of-day words (dusk, then the rising mist, then morning) and use them to set the verses in order, dusk to dawn. Asking **Pook the Puca** for his hint works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have Pook the Puca hum the first line, or point out the words "dusk" and "morning" and ask which one comes earlier in a night. Getting there with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: Playing It Together (Normal)

The challenge. The swan children know the words now but are too shy to sing, and the smallest swan is shyest of all. She cannot find her voice on her own.

Intended solution. This is a Social-emotional and Courage moment. The players lead the song rather than waiting for the swans: play the **little harp** to give them a tune to follow, sing along so no swan has to begin alone, and offer the shyest swan a kind word so she knows she is not on her own. When the players go first and stay beside her, she finds her note and the others follow.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or wait for the swans to start, have the shyest swan whisper, "Will you sing it with me?" The moment the players hum any tune at all and invite her in, her first small note slips free and all four swan children join the song.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a foe, only four shy swan children who had lost their song. When the lullaby returns, the grey mist lifts into rose and gold, the **Ring of Standing Stones** hums along, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down on the loch. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 1.5, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.